

33 Past regrets

You can use “should have” or “ought to have” to talk about past mistakes. They both signal that you wish you had done something differently in the past.

⚙️ **New language** “Should have” and “ought to have”

Aa **Vocabulary** Time markers

🧩 **New skill** Expressing regret about the past

33.1 KEY LANGUAGE “SHOULD HAVE” AND “OUGHT TO HAVE”

You use “should have” or “ought to have” to express regret about something that did not happen in the past. “Ought to” is less common than “should” and usually sounds more formal.



This bill is so big. I **should have** / **ought to have** used less electricity.



33.2 FURTHER EXAMPLES “SHOULD HAVE” AND “OUGHT TO HAVE”

Perhaps I **ought to have** used energy-saving light bulbs.

The negative form “ought not to have” is grammatically correct, but it is rarely used.

I **shouldn't have** fallen asleep with the TV on.



33.3 FILL IN THE GAPS USING “SHOULD HAVE” OR “SHOULDN'T HAVE”

We shouldn't have damaged the environment. It's becoming a long-term problem.

- 1 People _____ thrown things in the river. The fish population has declined dramatically.
- 2 Factories _____ reduced pollution in accordance with environmental agreements.
- 3 Companies _____ used fewer vehicles in order to lower their carbon footprint.
- 4 Factories _____ released pollution into the water. It has poisoned the ecosystem.

